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Adobe PDF is an ideal format for electronic document distribution as it overcomes the problems commonly encountered with electronic file sharing.

- *Anyone anywhere* can open a PDF file. All you need is the free Adobe Acrobat Reader. Recipients of other file formats sometimes can't open files because they don't have the applications used to create the documents.
- PDF files *always print correctly* on any printing device.
- PDF files always display *exactly* as created, regardless of fonts, software, and operating systems. Fonts, and graphics are not lost due to platform, software, and version incompatibilities.
- The free Acrobat Reader is easy to download and can be freely distributed by anyone.
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The development of PDF began in 1991 when John Warnock wrote a paper for a project then code-named Camelot, in which he proposed the creation of a simplified version of PostScript called Interchange PostScript (IPS).[8] Unlike traditional PostScript, which was tightly focused on rendering print jobs to output devices, IPS would be optimized for displaying pages to any screen and any platform.[8]

Adobe Systems made the PDF specification available free of charge in 1993. In the early years PDF was popular mainly in desktop publishing workflows, and competed with several other formats, including DjVu, Envoy, Common Ground Digital Paper, Farallon Replica and even Adobe's own PostScript format.

PDF was a proprietary format controlled by Adobe until it was released as an open standard on July 1, 2008, and published by the International Organization for Standardization as ISO 32000-1:2008,[9][10] at which time control of the specification passed to an ISO Committee of volunteer industry experts. In 2008, Adobe published a Public Patent License to ISO 32000-1 granting royalty-free rights for all patents owned by Adobe necessary to make, use, sell, and distribute PDF-compliant implementations.[11]

PDF 1.7, the sixth edition of the PDF specification that became ISO 32000-1, includes some proprietary technologies defined only by Adobe, such as Adobe XML Forms Architecture (XFA) and JavaScript extension for Acrobat, which are referenced by ISO 32000-1 as normative and indispensable for the full implementation of the ISO 32000-1 specification.[12] These proprietary technologies are not standardized, and their specification is published only on Adobe's website.[13][14][15] Many of them are not supported by popular third-party implementations of PDF.